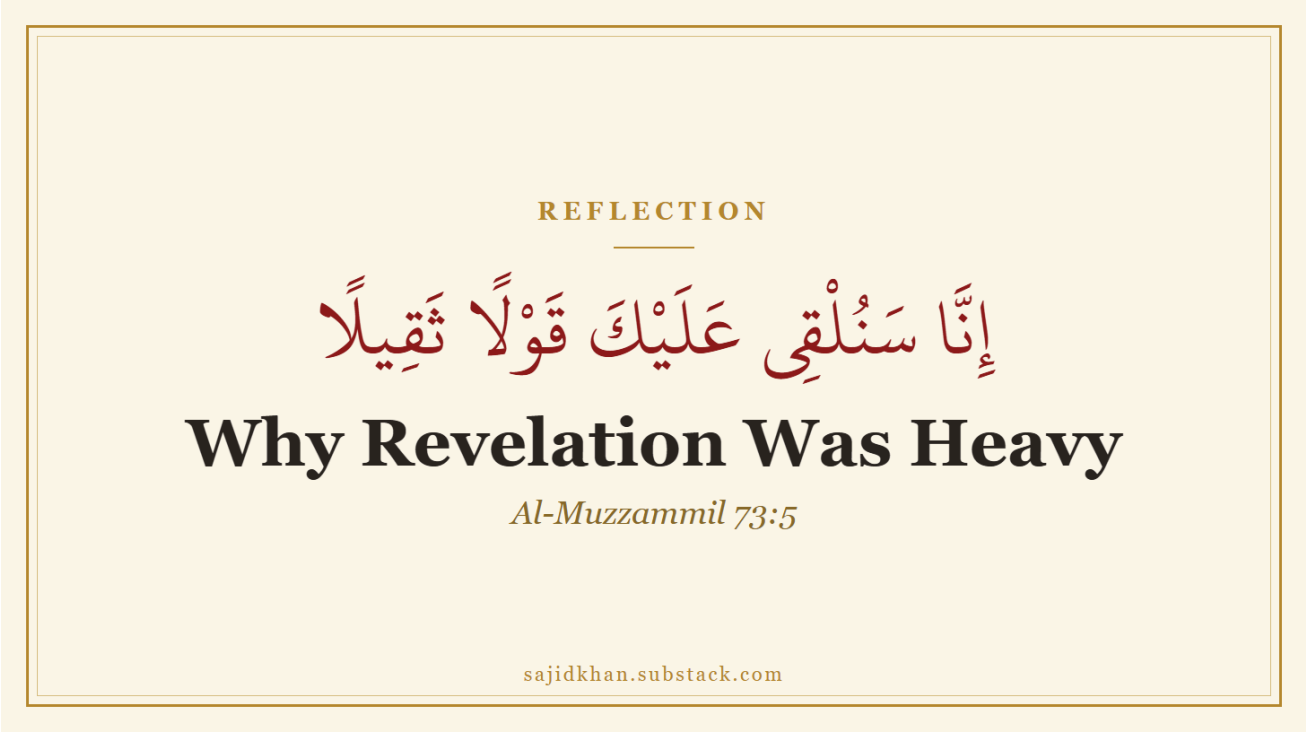



REFLECTION

# Why Revelation Was Heavy

*Ibn Khaldun on the Prophet's experience of wahy*

Allah told the Prophet ﷺ:

إِنَّا سَنُلْقِى عَلَيْكَ قَوْلًا ثَقِيلًا ۝٥

"We will send down to you a weighty word" (73:5). Revelation, *wahy* (وَحْى), was not easy to receive.

The great historian Ibn Khaldun (d. 1406) explains why in his *Muqaddimah*. In revelation, he says, the Prophet ﷺ was lifted for a moment beyond ordinary human perception to the level of the angels, so that he could receive the message. Leaving one's normal human state like this is hard and painful.

## What the hadiths describe

- **The first revelation:** in the cave of Hira, Jibril held him so tightly that he could bear no more, three times, and each time said "Read!" (Bukhari 3). Then came اقْرَأْ بِاسْمِ رَبِّكَ الَّذِى خَلَقَ "Read in the name of your Lord who created" (96:1).

- **The weight of it:** 'A'ishah said she saw revelation come to him on a very cold day, and when it ended his forehead was dripping with sweat (Bukhari 2).

## Getting used to it

Ibn Khaldun adds a striking point. As the Prophet ﷺ grew used to revelation, it became easier for him. That, he says, is one reason the early surahs revealed in Makkah are short, and the later passages revealed in Madinah are long.

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